

AEM Web Forms vs Adaptive Forms

Comparison and Migration Strategy for AEM as a
Cloud Service

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Adobe Professional Services – Edge Delivery Services



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AEM Web Forms vs Adaptive Forms

1. Overview

AEM provides two distinct approaches to form authoring. Web Forms (Foundation Forms) are the legacy approach, while Adaptive Forms represent the modern, actively developed solution. Understanding the differences is critical for migration planning from AEM 6.4 to AEM as a Cloud Service with Edge Delivery Services.

2. Comparative Matrix

Aspect	Web Forms (Foundation Forms)	Adaptive Forms
Architecture	Built on Foundation Components (Classic/ Coral UI)	Built on modern Form Container with Sling Models
Introduced	AEM 6.0 (legacy)	AEM 6.1+ (actively developed)
Responsive	No (fixed layout)	Yes (auto-adapts to device/screen)
Schema Support	Basic (no data binding)	XSD, JSON Schema, Form Data Model, XFA
Rule Editor	None	Visual rule editor (show/hide, enable/disable, calculate, validate)
Prefill Service	Not supported	Supported (prefill from CRM, DB, REST)
Submit Actions	Basic (email, store)	Extensible (REST, workflow, Forms Portal, custom)
Fragments	Not supported	Reusable form fragments across forms
Themes	CSS only	Theme editor + client libraries
Document of Record	Not available	Auto-generated PDF from form
E-Signatures	Not supported	Adobe Sign integration
Analytics	Basic	Adobe Analytics integration built-in
Lazy Loading	No	Yes (loads panels on demand)
Authoring	Drag and drop components on page	Dedicated form editor with panels/tabs/ wizards
Validation	Client-side only	Client + server-side, pattern-based
Accessibility	Limited	WCAG 2.0 AA compliant by design
Status	Deprecated (removed in AEMaaCS)	Active (recommended approach)

3. Key Differences in Detail

3.1 Layout and Responsiveness

Web Forms: - Fixed-width table/grid layout - Does not reflow on mobile devices - Authors must create separate mobile versions or rely on generic zoom behavior - No panel or section concept — all fields render in a single column or fixed grid

Adaptive Forms: - Fluid panels with responsive grid system - Authors choose layout patterns: wizard, tabs, accordion, or single panel - Auto-adjusts to any viewport (mobile, tablet, desktop) - Supports responsive breakpoints for field arrangement - Panel-level lazy loading reduces initial page weight

3.2 Data Integration

Web Forms: - Store data in CRX repository or send via email - No structured data model binding - Custom servlets required for any backend integration - No pre-fill capability from external systems

Adaptive Forms: - Bind to Form Data Model (FDM) connecting to: - REST APIs - JDBC databases - OData services - SOAP web services - Supports pre-fill from CRM, database, or custom data sources - Post-submit data operations (create, update, invoke service) - JSON Schema or XSD-based data binding for structured submissions

3.3 Authoring Experience

Web Forms: - Authors drag form components (text field, checkbox, dropdown) onto a page like any other AEM component - No dedicated form editing interface - Limited component palette - No visual preview of form behavior or validation

Adaptive Forms: - Dedicated form editor with: - Drag-and-drop into a form container - Panel/section organization - Repeatable sections (add/remove rows dynamically) - File attachment components - CAPTCHA integration - E-signature fields - Date picker, rich text, and custom components - Real-time preview mode - Mobile preview within the editor

3.4 Business Logic

Web Forms: - Requires custom JSP, Sling servlet, or JavaScript for any conditional logic - No visual authoring of business rules - Validation limited to basic required/pattern checks - Show/hide logic requires developer involvement

Adaptive Forms: - Visual Rule Editor allows authors to create if/then logic without code: - "If country = US, show state dropdown" - "If order total > \$1000, enable free shipping checkbox" - "Calculate total from quantity x unit price" - "Validate email format before submit" - Server-side validation rules prevent bypass - Custom functions can extend rule editor capabilities - Expression editor for advanced scenarios

3.5 Workflow Integration

Web Forms: - Manual integration with AEM Workflows via custom code - No built-in review/approval routing - No submission tracking or portal

Adaptive Forms: - Native integration with AEM Workflows: - Review and approval flows - E-sign routing (Adobe Sign) - Multi-step approval chains - Forms Portal for: - Draft saving and resumption - Submission tracking - Search across submitted forms - Automated email notifications at each workflow stage

3.6 Document of Record

Web Forms: - Not available - Must manually create PDF templates for record-keeping

Adaptive Forms: - Auto-generated PDF Document of Record from the form layout - Customizable DOR templates - Branded output with company logos and formatting - Useful for compliance, audit trails, and customer confirmation

3.7 Accessibility

Web Forms: - Limited ARIA support - No built-in screen reader optimization - Tab order not guaranteed - Error messaging not linked to fields

Adaptive Forms: - WCAG 2.0 AA compliant by design - Proper ARIA labels and roles - Keyboard navigable (all interactions) - Error messages linked to fields via aria-describedby - Focus management on validation errors - High-contrast theme support

4. Migration Context: AEM 6.4 to AEMaaCS (EDS)

4.1 Current State Impact

Consideration	Impact
Existing Web Forms	Must be rebuilt — Web Forms (Foundation Components) do not exist in AEMaaCS
Existing Adaptive Forms	Can migrate to AEMaaCS Adaptive Forms (Core Components) with the migration utility
Custom submit actions	Must be reviewed — some may need refactoring for cloud deployment
Form Data Models	Can be recreated in AEMaaCS; cloud-native data sources may differ
Workflows attached to forms	Must be rebuilt using AEMaaCS workflow engine

4.2 Target State Options in EDS

Form Complexity	Recommended Approach	Use Cases
Simple (1–5 fields, no logic)	EDS Form Block (spreadsheet-based)	Contact us, newsletter signup, event registration
Moderate (5–15 fields, basic logic)	EDS Form Block with custom rules	Quote requests, feedback forms, basic applications
Complex (multi-step, conditional, data integration)	Adaptive Forms (Core Components) via Universal Editor	Account registration, custom chemical orders, compliance forms, multi-step wizards
Highly regulated (e-signatures, DOR, audit trail)	Adaptive Forms + Adobe Sign	Legal agreements, medical consent, regulatory submissions

4.3 EDS Form Block

The EDS Form Block provides a lightweight, high-performance approach to forms:

- Form fields defined in a spreadsheet (Google Sheets or SharePoint)
- Rendered as native HTML form elements (fast, accessible)
- Submissions stored in spreadsheet or forwarded via webhook
- No server-side AEM dependency
- Custom validation via JavaScript
- Ideal for lead generation and simple data collection

Limitations: - No visual rule editor - No Form Data Model binding - No Document of Record generation - No native workflow integration - No form fragments or reuse across forms

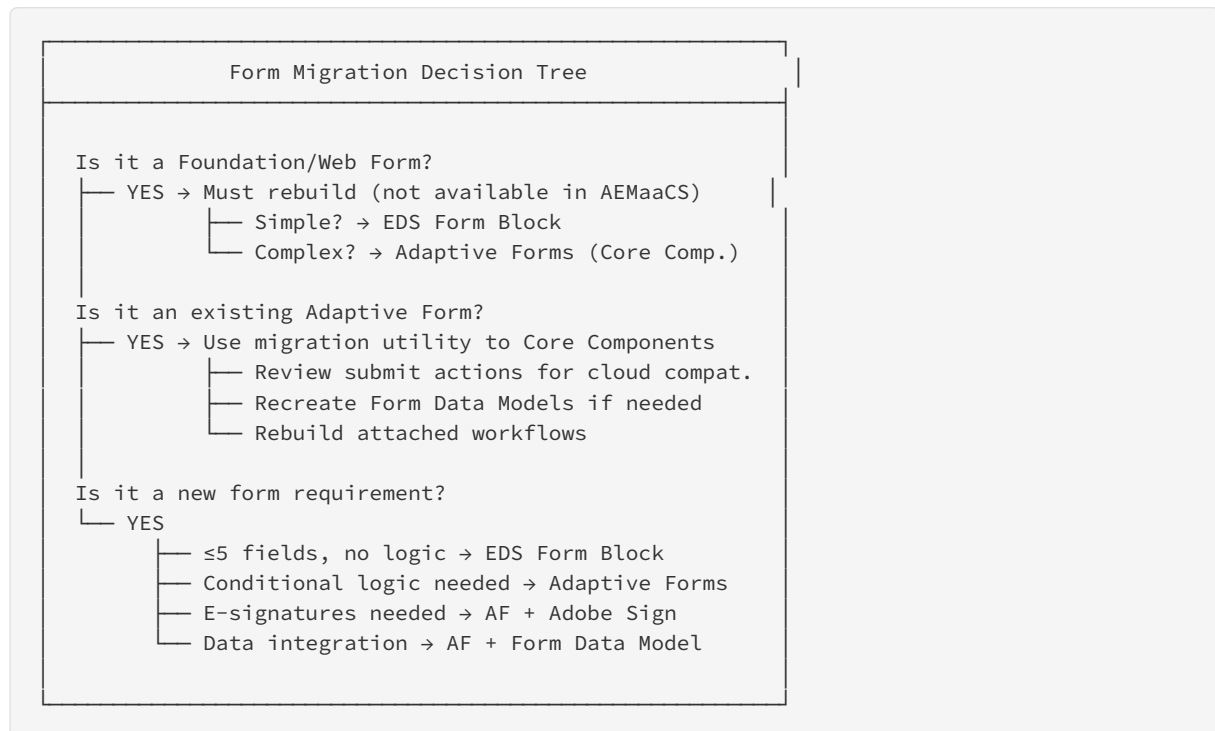
4.4 Adaptive Forms with Core Components (Universal Editor)

For complex forms requiring business logic, data integration, or compliance features:

- Full rule editor for conditional logic

- Bind to external APIs and databases
- Multi-step wizard with save/resume
- Document of Record generation
- Adobe Sign integration
- Forms Portal for draft/submission management
- Embedded in EDS pages via Universal Editor

5. Migration Decision Matrix



6. Thermo Fisher Specific Recommendations

Based on the thermofisher.com site analysis, the following form types were identified:

Form Type	Current Location	Complexity	Recommended Target
Contact Us	/home/technical-resources/contact-us.html	Moderate	EDS Form Block
Bulk Chemical Quote	/home/global/forms/lab-solutions/bulk-fine-chemicals.html	Complex	Adaptive Forms
Bioprocessing Contact	/home/global/forms/bioprocessing/contact.html	Moderate	EDS Form Block
Event Registration	Various event pages	Simple	EDS Form Block
Newsletter Signup	Header/footer	Simple	EDS Form Block
Account Registration	/store/ pages	Complex	Adaptive Forms

Form Type	Current Location	Complexity	Recommended Target
Custom Product Requests	Various product pages	Complex	Adaptive Forms
Download Gated Content	/home/global/forms/*/download-*.html	Simple	EDS Form Block

7. Summary

Decision Factor	Choose EDS Form Block	Choose Adaptive Forms
Number of fields	1–10	10+
Conditional logic	None or minimal	Required
Data prefill	Not needed	Required
Multi-step wizard	Not needed	Required
E-signatures	Not needed	Required
Document of Record	Not needed	Required
Backend integration	Webhook/spreadsheet sufficient	REST API/database binding needed
Performance priority	Maximum (no AEM dependency)	Good (AEM-rendered)
Authoring simplicity	Spreadsheet-based	Form editor UI
Form reuse (fragments)	Not needed	Required
Submission tracking	Basic (spreadsheet)	Full portal with search